Home Is Where The Heart Is

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Home Is Where The Heart Is

by EloyGray

Summary

Catra’s exhaustion began to fall away in sheets as she walked up the first flight of stairs, then down the hall and finally to the door home. Her hearing could pick up the hints of crying, but she couldn't make out where it was coming from. She trusted that if Adora had felt shitty, they would have texted her. A smile spread across her face as she pulled on the door hand, pulling her bag a little higher on her shoulder as she pushed open the door, expecting to see Adora's big, dorky smile.

Instead, she heard crying.

Adora's never been the best at talking about their feelings, despite Catra's insistence that they open up. One night, the weight of everything gets to her and Catra has the perfect cure.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

The pencil in Adora's hand threatened to snap at any moment, the wood already cracking from the pressure. Normally, Algebra homework was enough to make her want to slam her head into a wall, but this was different. Her mind had been all over the place recently, drowning in feelings of dysphoria and anxiety and fear and they didn't know why. Sure, the start of the school year always stressed them out, but this was her third year at college and she should be able to handle this by now. Taking care of herself recently had seemed impossible, no matter how-

A snap made her jump as the pencil finally gave way. In an instant her heart was in her throat, beating hard against her skin in a desperate plea to get out. Panic sunk it's claws into her mind as her breathing picked up, and the small room felt like it was closing in around her.

She was on the floor now, though when that happened Adora didn't know. Rough carpet scrapped against their palms as she pushed herself closer to the corner. Her back hit the wall, the small apartment swallowed by shadows as the panic attack they had been fighting off for days now finally set in, a cold winter finally arriving, and Catra wasn't even home to help them.

She felt a pressure against her side, and a familiar purring. For a second, she thought it was Catra, but the thought passed as she heard Melog's croaky meow. They forced their way onto her lap, rubbing their head against the flat of her stomach. Their purring continued, deep and tremorous, finding a home in the pit of her gut, providing a small amount of comfort as the world burned around her. The dam behind her eyes shattered, and the tears started to flow relentlessly, turning parts of her white hoodie gray. She hugged herself, desperate for some kind of physical connection as she sobbed, trying and failing to fight off wave after wave of unrelenting fear. She managed to croak out a few, broken words between her cries;

"I need you Catra."

Even if her and Adora's small apartment was only a few blocks from campus, it still exhausted Catra to have to walk there after a long day tutoring. She just didn't understand why some of the students couldn't get the material after she had explained it half a dozen times, in half a dozen different ways. What got her through was knowing that going home meant seeing Adora, her beautiful, amazing girlfriend. The thought of Adora's steel blue puppy-dog eyes, her platinum blonde hair that she only wore in a ponytail, the adorable laugh she made every time Catra cracked a dumb joke, it made her heart soar.

Pressing her key fob to the door, she heard the mechanical click that meant she could finally go inside. Entrapta had demanded to take apart the mechanism the first time she had visited, and it took Adora literally carrying her upstairs to get across the idea that she wasn't allowed to do that. Catra's exhaustion began to fall away in sheets as she walked up the first flight of stairs, then down the hall and finally to the door home. Her hearing could pick up the hints of

crying, but she couldn't make out where it was coming from. She trusted that if Adora had felt shitty, they would have texted her. A smile spread across her face as she pulled on the door hand, pulling her bag a little higher on her shoulder as she pushed open the door, expecting to see Adora's big, dorky smile.

Instead, she heard crying.

In an instant, her bag fell to the floor, keys clattering along with it. She called out, “Adora? Are you okay?” and waited for a response. She was already moving, not waiting for a reply. Her ears had zeroed in on where her girlfriend was, the sounds of quieted sobs bouncing around their apartment. Passing the low wall, Catra saw Adora sitting in the corner of their apartment, knees pulled to her chest and head pressed down, quiet weeping breaking the silence. Melog was with her, purring into her side and trying to calm her. The sight made her ears turn back and low, and she felt her tail instinctively curl around her ankle.

She tried to remember if Adora had texted or called her; she’s said a dozen times she’ll leave an appointment if Adora needs her. Without thinking, she pulled her phone from her pocket, but, no, there weren't any new texts or calls. Adora had never reached out. She wasn’t surprised, to be honest; Adora was terrible at taking up any space. Another thing that was Weaver’s fault. Sitting down, Catra quietly called out to her,

“Hey Adora?”

Adora’s head shot upwards, her pupils huge as surprise gripped her heart. Damnit, Catra should’ve known to walk louder, she has a bad habit of sneaking up on Adora and scaring her. Their heartbeat was so loud that she could hear it pounding against her chest from here. Hell, she could smell the panic and anxiety and endless *guilt* radiating off them.

Gently, she put a hand on Adora’s shoulder, hoping to give them some solace, and the fear painting Adora’s face subsided quickly. Catra moved a hand to Adora’s cheek, wiping away a tear, as her tail now wrapped protectively around Adora’s wrist. Her eyes were bleached red, along with the tear stains carved through her cheeks and chin. She could see that the top of her hoodie was completely soaked through.

How long had she been crying?

“Oh, hey Catra,” Adora’s voice was broken into a thousand pieces, raw and strained from crying. She hasn’t seen Adora this bad in, well, years actually. “I’m sorry you found-”

“Shut up.” She cut Adora off *hard* before they could even think about finishing that thought. She hated it when Adora apologized, mostly because Adora apologized for everything, even stuff that wasn’t her fault. She apologized for Melog interrupting Catra’s art, she apologized for the internet being down, hell, she apologized for it raining once! It broke Catra’s heart to see them in so much pain, and she knew that Adora felt like everything was *her fault*. “You don’t have anything to apologize for.”

Adora gave a weak, watery smile, clearly forcing it for Catra.

"Why don’t you tell me what happened Princess?”

Adora *hated* when Catra saw her like this. She pushed all of her friends, especially Catra, to be more open with their emotions and not to be afraid to cry in front of others, but she was different. She couldn't show any weakness; she had to be strong for her friends, be their protector, their guardian. That meant she couldn't let them know when she was feeling just so fucking awful. She should be strong enough to deal with it on her own.

It ruins her that she isn't.

Catra calling her *'Princess'* pulls her out of that spiral, just long enough for her to understand that Catra was saying something. The panic laying siege to their mind made them completely miss it, though.

"What'd you say?" She always felt so guilty asking people to repeat themselves, and it was worse for Catra since they knew Catra hated repeating herself. Another thing to beat herself up for.

"I asked what happened, dummy." Catra's hand on her cheek was warm, the soft fur making her feel safe for the first time in, gods, hours. Through teary eyes, Adora saw that Catra's ears were pressed back, though she felt the familiar softness of her tail wrapped around her forearm.

She looked behind Catra to the clock on the stove. *11:15*? That couldn't be right, she had only started her assignment at 7, and she had worked on it a little bit before This happened. Had she been crying for more than three hours?

A thumb wiped away another tear, and Adora came back to reality as she found Catra's unpaired eyes. They were brimming with concern and worry and love, and Adora finally found the words and forced them past the wet lump in her throat, after a false start.

"N- Nothing happened. I was doing my dumb history assignment and I just…" Her sentence trailed off without her, gone to the horizon. She looked down at the floor, and tried to force her legs closer to her chest. It didn't work, there wasn't any room left, but she needed to be small right now. To not take up any space.

She can *never* take up any space.

"Are you sure?" Catra was brushing their hair now, forcing one of the loose platinum tresses away from her face. Adora nodded slowly, her words locked away inside her somewhere. Catra frowned slightly, her other hand reaching out and finding space between Adora's. "Have you eaten today?"

Had she? She must've, right? Eating was so hard for her, even if Catra and her made dinners on the weekend, ready to be reheated for the rest of the week. There was also always ample food in the apartment, but even heating it up was a gargantuan task sometimes. "I had a peanut butter and jelly sandwich, I think." Was that really their voice? It was so small, so cracked, it couldn't be her.

“What else have you had?” Catra’s voice was full of concern now, taking on the motherly tone that always came out when Adora wasn’t taking care of herself. She looked away from Catra, shame welling in her heart and burning her cheeks crimson. She needs to be better about this.

“I’m not mad at you Adora, I just need to know.”

She shook her head no, and Catra sighed.

“Have you at least taken your meds today?”

Another shake no, another sigh.

A fresh wave of guilt pooled in Adora’s chest, a sudden onslaught of tears flooding her cheeks. They managed to force out an *'I’m so sorry'* between the sobs, but it wasn’t enough. She had let Catra down; another thing she felt awful about it.

“We should go to the bed. I love you, but I’m not getting my fur all dusty from sitting on the floor”

Catra was surprised when Adora went to the bed so willingly, but she was thankful. She fully expected to have to coax Adora there, since there was no way she could lift them, not with the height difference and the 50 pounds of muscle Adora had over her. She was grateful that Adora took the time to make their bed each morning, since it made it easier to climb over to them and hold her close. Adora was already holding one of the several plushies that lived near their bed, let alone the dozens scattered across their small room or her desk, all of which were Adora's. She was holding one that's she's had since she was a kid, one of the few possessions they were able to hide from Weaver.

Boiling hot rage filled Catra's lungs as she thought back to all the abuse and torture that their "caretaker" put the both of them through. How was it fair that she got to break Adora and Catra over and over and *over* again with no repercussions? To force them to spend years, decades, of hard work putting their broken minds back together, to untangle the massive knot of trauma and fear and programming that they shouldn't have to deal with? All while she got to live in some comfy house a thousand miles away?

Catra forced herself to breath; getting riled up about this wouldn't make her feel better, well, it would, but that isn't the point, and it certainly wouldn't help Adora. She needed to be there for her girlfriend, not in her own head.

She brushed more of her Adora's hair out of her face, letting her fingers run through the shaved sections on the sides of their head. She looked down at her, all red eyes and trembling lips, and Catra couldn’t believe how beautiful Adora was even as she cried. When Catra cried, she got all puffy and her fur stayed sticky and slick for another day or two, but Adora cried like an actual princess.

She had finally managed to force Adora's legs away from her chest, providing enough room for her to sit in her lap. She felt her purrs rumble into Adora's throat and chest, as she tried to make the involuntary action louder. Adora always said it helped calm her down, and if that was the case, Catra would purr for the rest of time, just for them.

"Tell me what's wrong, love."

"I just- I feel so guilty. I haven't done enough for you, and I'm a bad girlfriend, and I-" Catra knew where this was going. Better to cut her off before she kept rambling. She knew Adora well enough to know that if she didn't step in, she would just keep spiraling until she started to hurt herself.

"Adora, you haven't done anything wrong. You have *nothing* to be sorry for. I'm the one who told you to rest today, right?" Catra knew that the only way to get Adora to relax was to order her to, and even then, Adora never really relaxed. She had been working herself to the bone, and Catra knew that when Adora started doing that things weren't good in her girlfriend's head. So, she made them promise her to take today off, to just rest and do a little bit of homework and nothing more. She hoped it would be enough to get them out of this funk.

It wasn't.

"I know," Adora continued, her voice broken and coarse. The crying had clearly done a number on her. She must have been crying for hours for her voice to be that raw. "I just- Gods Catra, I feel *awful* . I feel like the worst girlfriend in the world and a huge disappointment."

It broke Catra's heart to hear Adora talk like this. She always held herself to impossible standards, never letting herself rest and always taking responsibility for other people. In the group home, Weaver had fed Adora lie after lie that she needed to protect everyone, that she alone always had to shoulder the burden and be responsible. That she had to be the *'man'* of the house. All of those were hilariously wrong, just like everything else that bitch had told them, but the nails of their abuse had been hammered home hard, and it was exhausting, bitter work to pull them out.

Her hand fell down to Adora's cheekbones, and the pads of her fingers felt the telltale prick of stubble. If Adora wasn't shaved, then it must've been a few days at least since she last showered. Adora pulled away slightly at Catra's touch, before stopping themself and letting it happen.

"I'm sorry about *that* too." Her voice was so full of shame it almost broke Catra. She wishes she could beam into Adora's brain that she nothing to be ashamed about, especially when it comes to her body. Another thing Weaver had weaponized against them, and another thing for Catra to never ever forgive her for.

"Adora, I love *all* of you. You're always beautiful. If you weren't, I'd find someone else. I mean, do you know how many people I have to fight off every day?" Adora smiled at the comment, knowing it was in jest, and Catra felt her heartbeat against her sternum. "You have nothing to be sorry about Princess. You're allowed to take time off, especially when I force you to."

“You promise?” Adora gave her a look of desperation, tears starting to well in her eyes again. The words pierced Catra’s heart, forcing her to remember all the times they had asked each other that very question. They had asked each other to promise to always being there for each other, about Adora loving her when she came out as a lesbian, about Catra loving Adora when *she* came out as a woman, and dozens upon dozens of other things. It had become a sort of code that just the two of them could ever understand; a sign of hopelessness, and the desperate need of reassurance.

“I promise.”

Adora couldn’t help but smile. Hearing Catra say those words, it always made her feel better. Every time she has asked Catra that, it was out of an anguished need to feel loved. And every time, Catra has been there to catch her and remind her of that love.

The memory of when she first came out to Catra flooded their mind, whisking them away from the present. It happened during her senior year of high school; It had been an impossible day at school and track practice, and when she came home, Miss Weaver laid into her about how she wasn’t being a good example of what a “man” should be by growing her hair out. That she needed to act more like some of the other boys at the group home, and finally take command of the people around her. It turned into a horrible yelling match, ending with Adora finally standing her ground after years of abuse, the taste of freedom a few months away giving her the courage that was critical to her survival.

That night, with tears in her eyes and fear suffocating her heart, she had rolled over and asked Catra if she was awake. Before Catra could even ask what she wanted to talk about, Adora’s heart burst and words poured from her mouth. She fell into a half-crying, half-angry rant about Weaver and her expectations that ended with her choking out *'I don’t even want to be a man'* around chocked sobs. Catra didn’t say anything for a while, but she was holding Adora’s hand the whole time and eventually told her *'Okay'* and reassured her that she would survive this. And when Adora made her promise, Catra promised.

“Etheria to Adora? You there?”

Catra’s words yanked Adora back to reality, the feeling of soft fur on her cheek filling her with love. Sometimes she still expected to hear Catra say another name, but she never has, not since she had quietly whispered *‘Adora’* on the couch in their tiny apartment three years ago. She felt Catra’s fur catch on her stubble, reminding her that she hadn’t shaved in days and causing her background dysphoria to bubble up. Recently, she could barely feed herself, let alone do basic grooming and upkeep, even if it tanked her mental state even more. Catra’s mismatched, teal and amber eyes were full of concern, her pupils slitted in the bright room. The light made her dark fur glow auburn, the lighter markings looking like golden inlays in her pattern.

“Yeah, sorry. I’m here,” Adora said, rubbing her eyes. The tears seemed to have finally stopped, though that may simply be because she cried them all out. The top of her hoodie was soaked, the wet fabric sticking to her skin uncomfortably. “I really did a number to this thing,” she said, though their voice was still coarse. It was nice to be verbal again, at least.

“Yeah, you did. Also, you reek. I mean you really smell terrible.” Catra tapped her forehead as she said it, and Adora couldn’t help but smile. She was safe.

“Yeah, well, you’re always going on about how you like my scent, so.” Adora shrugged at the end of her sentence, a new feeling growing in her throat: mischief. Catra started to say something about there being a difference between scents, especially comparing now and *before*, but Adora cut her off by grabbing the back of her head and rubbing it into her chest, making sure to do it below the tear stains.

“Aghh! Get off! Stop!!” Catra hollered, forcing the words out between laughter as she struggled to wiggle out from Adora’s grip. Reaching to one of their flanks, Catra started to tickle Adora, adding more laughter to the chaos and finally allowing her to escape. Her tail was slightly puffed out, and Melog was looking curiously at the two of them, but Adora could see the smile on Catra’s face. She rubbed her nose as Adora’s laughter died down, before adding, “Gods, you *really* need a shower, you know that?”

“I’ve had a rough week!”

A grin replaced Catra’s smile, and a hand started to run up Adora’s thigh. Air caught in her throat, stealing her thoughts away and leaving feelings in their place. Feelings of warmth grew in the pit of her stomach, and *lower*, feelings of fear and apprehension but also of love and safety. But mostly, there was a feeling of lust as Catra’s grin grew bigger.

“We could change that, you know. I haven’t showered today either.”

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Catra was honestly surprised that Adora had said yes so quickly to her suggestion. She knew Adora was quick to bounce back, but she was fully expecting them to tell her to get her head out of the gutter, or that they should at least eat first. Instead, she practically felt Adora’s heart skip a beat, and even with her hearing she struggled to hear Adora whimper out *'Can we?'*. The confirmation was nice, but she was practically swimming in the smell of Adora's arousal by the time they agreed.

It wasn’t a long walk to their bathroom, considering that it was attached to their bedroom, but it gave her time to hug Adora and actually kiss her. She realized that she hadn’t kissed Adora once since she had gotten home, and that had to change. The moment Adora was standing, Catra grabbed hold of the neck of her shirt and pulled them down into a kiss, letting her trail wrap around their waist. It started tender, a soft reminder of their love, before it grew more passionate. Catra bit down on Adora’s bottom lip before she felt their tongue slide into her mouth, warm and familiar, as her own felt the sweet with a hint of saltiness taste of her girlfriend’s lips. Catra’s hand was already on her girlfriend’s throat, applying familiar and gentle pressure, her claws digging slightly into their skin. It wasn’t long until Adora’s hoodie was a pile on the floor.

It stopped there, for now at least. Adora rightfully pointed out that if they kept going, she would never get the chance to shower, even as Catra fake pouted about it, forcing her ears down. It was worth it, though, since Catra got to see them in just their round glasses and *her* pajama shorts, which did nothing to hide their growing arousal.

Catra leaned against the doorframe as Adora fumbled with the shower controls. In an instant, water fell from the rainfall head Adora had spent hours installing the day after they moved in. The sound of it splashing against the linoleum filled the room as Adora leaped backwards to avoid getting wet. They had chosen this apartment specifically because of the shower; a box big enough for two, if they squeezed, and a glass door instead of curtains. They wanted a shower as different as possible from the one in their old group home; they had both spent too many nights crying in there to want to carry that weight with them. They certainly could've afforded a slightly larger apartment with their educational stipend, but the decided to splurge for this creature comfort.

The door still open, Adora turned around and kissed Catra again. She let her hands rub against Adora's stomach and around to her hips, feeling the tense muscle beneath the thin layer of softness. She loved that Adora was just a little bit softer now, a side effect of the treatment. It gave her more to knead, which she was doing right now, her fingers grabbing at the plush skin. Adora pulled away too soon, their tongue pulling from Catra's lips and leaving a rush of cool air in it's place. For a moment, Catra wanted to grab her by the ponytail and pull them back in, but when she realized why Adora pulled away, she chose to wait.

Adora's thumbs slipped into the waistband of her shorts, and started to pull downwards. A tiny patch of platinum hair, a shade darker than the rest, had been revealed, just enough to make Catra realize just how *wet* she was, before Adora stopped. Catra looked at her, and their eyes were filled with hesitance.

"I haven't shaved in a few days." Adora's voice was small, clearly afraid that Catra would change her mind. Instead, she rolled her eyes and placed her hand on the tantalizing patch of hair, running her fingers through it.

"I don't care, you goober." Getting a nod of approval, Catra's hand pushed the shorts down the rest of the way, letting Adora's cock bounce free. Her hands trailed downwards, the just barely coarse hair on their pelvis meshing with her fur. Catra found what she was looking for, and wrapped her hand around her girlfriend's length, pulling a soft whimper from Adora in the process. She was already hard, heat cascading into Catra's hand as she felt a familiar heartbeat through her cock. She gave a single stroke, and then another, and Adora whimpered at the pleasure, a bead of pre-cum already forming at the tip. Catra caught the drop on her thumb, before pressing it into Adora's mouth. Another gorgeous sound filled the air as their whole body shuddered, flooding Catra's underwear even more. She had to get out of them before they were completely ruined. "I just want you."

With a smile, Adora painfully broke their connection as she continued to fidget with the shower. Seeing Adora, comfortable and happy in a body that suits her, always lit Catra's heart aflame. She remembers when she felt horrible guilty for finding Adora attractive, back in high school after she had come out as a lesbian but while Adora was still pretending to be something she wasn't. The shame and fear had infected her body like termites, making Catra spend years questioning something she knew she was so sure of, *with a single exception*. The night Adora had come out brought everything into clarity, like a puzzle piece falling into place. She still wishes she had said something instead of just saying *'Okay'* like a fucking idiot. In fairness, *'I fucking knew I was a lesbian'* was playing on repeat in her head.

“You gonna shower too, or are you just gonna watch me like a creep?” Adora stepped into the shower, and motioned for Catra to join.

“I know for a fact how much you like it when I *‘just watch’*, dork,” Catra shot back as she peeled her leggings completely off, tossing them to the floor. She went to pull off her bodysuit and noticed that she *had* completely soaked through her underwear, leaving a small dark spot between her legs. She heard a moan, and saw Adora leaning against the far wall, idly playing with one of her nipples. Her senses were sent into overdrive at the sight and smell of Adora playing with herself, and Catra practically ripped the bodysuit off. Finally, she got to take all of Adora in as she walked into the shower.

Adora’s body was beautiful in every way. She had the softest skin Catra had ever felt, feeling like fresh cotton to the touch. Even the numerous scars and recent stretch marks that lined her body felt incredible beneath her fingers. The color matched her platinum hair; alabaster with hints of pink underneath that flushed cherry red whenever she exercised, showered, felt embarrassed, or climaxed. Catra pressed a hand to Adora’s chest as their lips met, rolling one of their breasts in her hand. They had grown so much in the past three years, completely removing the need, or want, Adora felt to get any type of surgery. She couldn’t even fit the whole thing in her hand anymore, hell, they were bigger than hers. She found one of Adora’s nipples, hard and bright pink, the same color as her lips and the head of her cock, and rubbed it between her fingers. A high pitched moan filled her mouth, and Catra let her other hand trail downwards as Adora's hands finally started to play with her tits.

Catra absorbed every touch she could, tracing the outline of Adora’s abs with her claws, feeling the dip where her legs connected to her hips, and the way she shuddered when her hand got closer to her prize. She gently grabbed Adora’s cock, and they went rigid, another moan pouring out of them as her eyes rolled back into her head. Catra felt electric pleasure run through her chest as Adora started to play with her nipples, causing her train of thought to stutter and stall for a moment. Feeling her girlfriend’s cock twitch in her hand brought her back to reality. It was smaller than when they had first started dating, something they had been warned about, but Catra didn’t mind. In fact, she loved it more now; she could fit the whole thing in her mouth, and it just fit her better in general.

Making good on that thought, Catra dropped to her knees, and looked up at Adora. With a entirely too seductive lick of her lips, their eyes went wide with anticipation, and a small nod of consent was all Catra needed to start sucking her dick.

Adora’s mind flooded with pleasure as she felt Catra take her into her mouth. She kissed the head, before sucking on just the first inch, clearly trying to tease Adora. It worked, and Adora let out another moan as she braced herself against the shower wall. One hand shot up to one of her breasts and started playing with a nipple, desperate for more pleasure.

Catra removed her cock from her mouth, letting cool air and warm water fall onto it. Adora whimpered at the sudden lack of stimulation, and she couldn’t suppress her hips bucking once, desperate to feel something. They looked down to see Catra grinning, her ears pressed completely flat against her head, and watched as she ran her tongue from base to tip before plunging back down. Sensation burned in Adora’s core, climbing into her throat. Tension

coiled around her spine as Catra continued to suck her off, her fangs providing a sharp edge to the stimulation.

She could feel Catra moaning, and a quick glance downwards confirmed that Catra was already playing with her clit, which made the burning pleasure even harder to rein in. Adora felt like her head was spinning, her hand now fallen to rest on the top of Catra's, letting her fingers running through her short hair. They weren't putting any pressure down, the last time Adora had tried that she had gotten tied up and pleasantly tortured, but it was still nice to feel Catra's coarse mane between her fingers. Knowing how much Catra liked her ears played with, Adora ran one of them between her thumb and forefinger, squeezing gently as she rubbed the thin skin. Catra mewled at that, her purring only adding to the flame rapidly engulfing Adora's soul.

She felt Catra's tail wrap around her ankle, and that's when she knew she was getting close. Adora was always easy to get off, her libido always ran high, but she had been so pent up lately that she hadn't been able to actually do anything about it. Fiery tension continued to coil around her spine, rocketing up her throat and into her mind. "Catr-ahh, I- I'm so- I'm-close," they tried to speak out, to give her some warning but instead Catra just kept bobbing her head. Adora felt another layer of silky warmth as Catra pressed her nose against their pelvis, and it pushed them over the edge. Adora choked out a loud, whimpering moan as she almost doubled over, both hands on the back of Catra's head. She came hard, spilling into and down Catra's throat, her constant purr adding to the waves of pleasure. Each wave came crashing down onto Adora, another slamming into her right as the first abated, giving her no time to breath, not that she wanted it. Adora's eyes were screwed shut, but she could feel Catra smiling.

As her orgasm was finally washing away, Adora's let her head fall backwards, resting on the shower wall as Catra pulled off her softening dick. As Adora started to say *'That was amazing'* she was cut off by Catra's hands on her shoulders pulling her down as her tail curled tightly around her waist. Her lips found Adora's, and before they could even react, they felt Catra forcing their own come into their mouth. It tasted sweet and salty, and mixed with Catra's own taste it was intoxicating. Catra pulled away, Adora's mouth now completely full.

"Now be a good girl and swallow for me." The order sent electricity up her spine and back down her cock. Adora did as she was told, and swallowed hard, before looking down and watching a massive smile spread across Catra's face, her fangs ever present. "Good job Princess, I'm proud of you."

Adora's knees buckled when she heard that, and it took all of her strength not to fall over completely. Catra laughed, and Adora was about to say something, but Catra beat her to it.

"Your hair is still up, and you still have your glasses on, dummy." A hand raced up, and she felt cool metal and glass between her fingers. Catra laughed again, pressing into Adora's chest, her purr echoing through Adora's body, her tail still wrapped around their hips.

"Don't you want to get off?

“Don’t worry, you’ll make sure I do. But first, I want you to actually get clean.” Catra’s words found their place in Adora’s heart, sinking in and staying there. She always felt safest around Catra, more so than anyone else, even Bow or Glimmer, and this was one of the infinite reasons why. No matter how bleak things seemed, no matter how awful she felt, Catra always knew exactly how to turn things around and make her feel better. She always knew how to show Adora that she really, honestly cared about their well being.

As she started to wash her hair and Catra rubbed herself down with soap, her mind wandered to the same fantasy she always had after they had sex; Catra wearing a stunning red and black suit with a white and gold capelet slung over one arm. Herself in a gorgeous, matching white and gold dress with a high neckline and tight in the torso. All of their friends and their found family choosing to spend a day celebrating them and their love. She didn’t know when, but Adora knew that one day soon, they were going to propose to Catra.

“Are you crying again? What’s wrong?” She didn’t feel the tears in the shower, but she knew they were there. They smiled down at their girlfriend, bright and big and full of love, before planting a kiss on her lips. She wrapped an arm around Catra’s ass, and picked her up, bringing her eye to eye.

“I just love you so much Catra.”

Catra blushed hard, mirrored by Adora’s own burning.

“I love you too, Adora.”

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

Honestly I don't know how long this story will go, but I'm not comfortable making the chapters read "x/?" since that puts pressure on me to keep writing past any end point I like. I hope you enjoy enjoy. Porn ends past the ***

Content Warning:
This chapter contains mentions of childhood abuse, as well as panic attacks and dissociation, as well as concerns about dubious consent (that are completely unfounded). This is still suppose to be a feel good fic, but part of I love about this ship is their interconnect traumas. You've been warned if any of that makes you uncomfy.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra rubbed the fur on her left arm with the towel again, causing it to poof out and stand on end. It didn't *hurt*, not really, but it was certainly far from comfortable. After she had helped get Adora off, she had quickly washed herself and gotten out of the shower, even if she didn't want to leave her girlfriend's embrace. Adora still needed to actually bathe and shave, and Catra would just get in the way. Standing just outside of the shower box, Catra continued to rub dry shampoo into her coat, though her conversation with Adora never stopped.

"I'm home for less than an hour and you pounce on me. Can't say I'm surprised Adora"

"Hey! Y- You were the one who suggested we shower together!" Adora's voice was higher pitched than normal, clearly surprised at the accusation. Catra rolled her eyes with enough emphasis that even Adora could see it without her glasses.

"Yeah, well, you were the one who got hard. Must be because I'm so hot." A shrug followed her words as she turned around, pressing both of her palms against the sink and leaning backwards just a bit. She heard Adora swallow hard, her eyes wandering up and down her naked body. Catra couldn't surprise the shiver that ran up her spine as she watched their hungry eyes take her in. She knew how much Adora loved her body, and this shampoo always made her coat silkier and softer than normal.

"Y- Yeah, well- You- I- " Adora continued to stumble over her sentence, giving it a few more good tries before deciding better of it once Catra's giggle turned into a laugh. She stuck her tongue out at them for good measure, before turning back to the mirror and started to inspect her coat. She spent a few minutes checking over it before coming to the tuft of fur between her legs. It was longer than the rest of her fur, coarser too, like her mane, but she knew Adora

loved it. She ran her fingers through the hair, debating whether to trim it or not before she heard a bang and a clatter as Adora fell to the floor.

It was only a few steps before Catra was at the door, looking down at Adora. She was splayed out on the floor, wet platinum hair covering their blue-grey eyes, hands still planted against the wall after having tried, and failed, to save herself.

“You idiot,” was all Catra could say as she rolled her eyes, and reached down to help them get back on her feet. Standing back up, the smell of fresh blood caught Catra’s nose, and a quick inspection showed that Adora had cut herself badly with the razor as she fell. Thankfully, it was just on her inner thigh instead of somewhere more delicate, but she still couldn’t believe how clumsy Adora was. “You’re bleeding.”

“I am?” Adora looked down, checking to see if she was and, lo and behold, she saw that she was. Quickly, she turned the shower off and pressed a hand against the wound.

“Yes, you are. Now sit on the toilet before you bleed everywhere.”

Catra had already doubled back across the room to get the small first aid kit they kept in their apartment. Returning to Adora, she saw that they had done as she asked, sitting and holding pressure on their leg. *‘At least she’s good at following orders”* Catra thought, trying to push down a toothy smirk.

She placed the medical kit next to her, and put a hand on the inside of each of Adora’s knees. Spreading her legs gave a conflicting view; on the one hand, her girlfriend was freshly bleeding. On the other, she could see her freshly shaved, beautiful balls and already half hard cock. Feeling a bolt run through her spine and into her core, she pushed the thought of getting railed into the mattress away until she could stop the bleeding.

Moving Adora’s hand away, Catra applied a small amount of antibiotic ointment to the wound. Adora whined in response, her hands going into a white knuckle grip. “It doesn’t hurt that bad, you big baby.” Catra’s voice, even as she teased Adora, helped calm them down enough for her to apply the bandage. To make sure it was on, she gave it a little smack, and a hiss escaped Adora’s mouth. “So what did we learn today Adora?”

“Be more careful in the shower?” Their answer was almost a question, their face sheepish and full of guilt. A sigh escaped Catra’s mouth, and she felt her ears fall backwards as she thought back on all the times they patched each other up in the group home. Weaver never helped, of course, hell, she never did anything besides scold them.

“I’m not mad at you Adora, you just need to be more careful, okay?” A small smile crested across Adora’s face, and Catra thought her heart was going to positively *melt* at seeing that. She hadn’t even realized she was rubbing her hands up and down Adora’s thighs until-

“Your hands are really soft.” Their voice was quiet, barely audible over Catra’s own purring, which she hadn’t realized she was doing until right now. She tried to stifle the noise, but it didn’t work, and instead she felt a warmth rising in her cheeks. Adora clearly felt the same way, considering theirs were now bright crimson.

“Someone has to have soft hands between the two of us.” It was a lie, of course; Adora’s hands were just as soft, despite all the rock climbing and weaponry drills she did. When they had enrolled, neither of them knew that the college had a weaponry club, and the moment Adora found that out it was like watching her fall in love all over again. Honestly, she felt a little jealous of the swords the first time she watched Adora handle one, they way her fingers curled around the shaft, the carved muscle in her arms changing and stretching with each strike, the delicate way they treated the weapon.

Adora looked at her, their eyes massive orbs that seemed to just suck the world in around them. Catra regularly got lost in them, amazed at how their color could seem to change from sky blue to a steel grey depending on the lighting, or how they always carried so much love and joy and resilience. Her hand cupped Adora's cheek, their smile warm and unsure. Her hair still a wet mop falling all over her head, though it was easier to take care of now. They shaved the sides a months back at least, but her hair was still so thick and Catra just didn’t get how Adora lived with it.

“Do you want to go to the bedroom?” Again, Adora’s voice was soft, unsure of whether Catra was still interested in picking up where they left off. Catra could feel how completely soaked she still was, the fur between her thighs slick and warm, and seeing Adora smile down at her like this made her even wetter. Her eyes glanced downwards, seeing that Adora was completely hard now, and she felt herself grin wide enough that her fangs were clear as day.

“Carry me there, big girl?”

Whenever Catra asked Adora to carry her, it made their heart flutter. Adora *loved* carrying Catra, but she never got to do it as often as she wanted. In fairness, ‘as often as she wanted’ was ‘literally all the time’, so her reluctance made sense. Out in public, Catra was incredibly reluctant to let Adora carry her, but when they were home, in the apartment, all bets were off.

With little effort, Adora grabbed Catra by the waist and pulled her upwards, their eyes meeting each other. Catra wrapped her legs around Adora’s hips, as her arms found purchase wrapped up and around her shoulders. She sucked in air as her vision went white for a moment as Catra’s tail wrapped around the top of her thigh, just high enough to brush her balls with her movement. From this angle, she could feel herself lightly pressing against Catra’s entrance. It would be *so easy* for her to thrust in and connect them, but Adora knew they had to wait.

Walking out of the bathroom, Melog gave her a slight rowl as she carried Catra to the bed. She was purring, she always purred whenever Adora held her, the sound sending vibrations through her ribs and collarbone. It didn’t help that Catra had rested her head in the crook of Adora’s neck, ghosting kissing on the hollow of their throat. Catra was making it almost impossible for Adora to actually focus on the task at hand. If she fell, Catra would jump from her arms and undoubtedly leave scratch marks, and not the fun kind. Hell, they might even scar, and she already had plenty of those from when they fought and wrestled on and off until the end of high school.

They shook their head, banishing the thoughts as she gently sat down onto the bed. Catra mewled at the motion, lifting her head from it's resting place and bringing her hands up to their cheeks. Her thumb rubbed over Adora's cheekbone, her head tilting slightly to one side before her thumb traced their jaw and pressed onto, and then into, their lips. Adora let out a small whimper, her breath stuttering as she exhaled. She could feel herself twitch against Catra's pussy, feeling some of her slick run down the length of their shaft.

"So, what do you want?" Catra's voice was cool, flowing easily into the air despite the situation at hand. Adora loved it when Catra was in control; it made it so easy for her to just *let go* and want things, something she always struggled with. If Catra was ordering her, then it was okay for her to want, because it wasn't for it, it was for *Catra*. They stared back at her, half-lidded eyes hazy and full of lust. She removed her finger from Adora's mouth with a loud popping sound, and Adora knew exactly what she need- No, what she *wanted*.

"I want to get you off."

Catra laughed at that a little, letting her hand fall to Adora's throat and pressing gently against it. They could still breath just fine, but the distant pressure was more than enough of a reminder of who exactly was in control here.

"Yeah, you are gonna get me off. I meant how, dummy."

There was a time where the teasing would have hurt Adora, where it *did* hurt Adora, but that was long ago. She knows now that the moment it makes her uncomfortable, Catra stops until it's okay again. They don't even need to say it anymore, Catra just knows how she is feeling in the same way Adora knows what Catra needs. She loves so much that they are connected like that, able to intuit what the other needs.

Adora's words came out slowly, carefully chosen to make sure they were correct. "Do you- Can I-" Their breath caught, and they forced themself to focus before continuing.

"I want to fuck you, if that's okay."

Catra's face lit up like a flashlight, a massive grin spreading that made Adora's heart positively soar.

"I thought you'd never ask."

It didn't take long for Adora to press Catra into the mattress. Their elbows were astride Catra's head, taking all of their weight as she wrapped her legs around their waist. Her tail, meanwhile, trailed between Adora's legs, gently rubbing against her balls or her thigh or even her asshole, just enough to make her shiver and whimper.

Adora planted a few kisses down Catra's neck, making sure to kiss her ears and all the sensitive spots as well. Catra was already mewling, unable to keep the noises from spilling out of her. Once she felt Adora lined up with her entrance, she rested her hands on their larger shoulders, and gave her a nod of approval.

There was a burning below her gut as Adora entered, slowly and consistent, giving Catra time to adjust to her size. After years of hormones, Adora was just *finally* getting to a size where Catra can take her comfortable, a thought that was ever present in her mind as Adora carefully, slowly, finally bottomed out. Catra felt sweat start to form on her brow, and she looked down between their bodies to see Adora's golden tuft of hair pressed firmly against hers. With a kiss and a nod, Adora gradually pulled out before plunging back in, her thrusting starting in earnest. The moment they were hilted again, Catra let out a loud moan right into her ear.

Adora continued to increase her pace, their lips connected now. Catra felt them part her lips, and she let her tongue explore her girlfriend's mouth, moans and whimpers following with it. She was getting more soaked by the minute, the burning completely gone after the first few thrusts and replaced entirely with a coiling tension tightening around the base of her spine. One of her hands dug into Adora's shoulder, her claws sure to leave faint scratch marks as her other hand found her clit. Desire forced her hand as she started to rub herself with two fingers, feeling the pleasure increase and start to overload her system.

"Gods, fuck Adora you feel so good inside me." Catra moaned as she bore down on Adora, pulling a moan from her lungs alongside a barrage of *'I love you'* s and praise. Adora adjusted her position slightly, and when she began thrusting again Catra's vision went white. Her cockhead was perfectly pressed against her g-spot at the start of each thrust, pressing hard against the soft flesh. She reached down between her legs, using her forefinger to rub gentle circles around her clit, only adding to the building pressure.

"Fu-uck Catra, I- I'm close- Do you-"

She was staring at Adora's eyes, the pleasure building behind them as clear as her own. She could feel how close she was, and she could tell from the stutters in Adora's thrusts they were too. Selfishly, she wanted to string this out a little longer. She needed to feel Adora inside of her for more than just a handful of minutes.

"Hold out for me just a little longer, okay?"

Her voice was rough, the tone riding and falling each time Adora thrusted. She could feel the slight, giving warmth of their length and Catra gripped down, her muscles coiling and rolling with Adora. The smell of sex and arousal filled the room, completely overwhelming Catra and slowly shutting off her brain. She knew they was close, doing their best to follow her instructions. She wanted to give Adora the satisfaction of having followed her orders, allowing them to feel like they did something right today, even if they had done everything right in Catra's mind.

The pressure building inside her was reaching a breaking point as she kept rubbing her clit, the sounds of Adora's legs slapping against her ass only adding to her arousal. Catra knew her climax was about to slam into her, and she wanted to feel Adora unravel alongside her.

"Come inside me Princess."

Adora thrust into her three more times, each less controlled than the last, before hilting themself as Catra felt Adora come inside her. She felt her cock grow and flex against her

walls with each spurt as Adora spilled everything she had, boiling warmth coating her walls and filling her. Adora half-whined half-groaned as she came, an exhausted sound that was full of pleasure, and that was enough to push Catra over the edge too. The coil inside of her snapped, forcing her to clamp down onto Adora and feel every inch of their shaft inside of her as she gushed onto both of their thighs, and the bed beneath. Her fingers were erratic against her clit as she came, her other hand fully digging into the base of Adora's skull and her sunshine platinum hair. Catra heard Adora's name come from her mouth in a moan, her eyes squeezed shut hard as the final throes of her orgasm died down.

Opening her eyes, she saw Adora looking at her, all heart eyes and big, goofy smiles, and Catra couldn't help but blush. She melted when Adora did that, always had, and it made them impossible to resist. Catra wiggled underneath Adora, feeling her softening dick still distinctly inside of her.

"Stop looking at me like that," Catra whined, though her purring betrayed her true feelings.

"I'm looking at you like this because you're the most beautiful woman in the world, and I love you." Adora leaned down and gave Catra a tender kiss, before finally pulling out and fetching a towel. They had learned together that leaving their mixed slick to dry into Catra's coat was a horrible idea. As they rounded the bed, Catra made sure to give their ass a half hearted slap as she added,

"You're gonna rot my teeth out."

From the bathroom, Adora called back, "That's the idea!" in a sing-song voice, and Catra's heart just drowned in joy. She loved how silly Adora was, how sometimes she would just realize something that seemed obvious to everyone else, like how buffalo wings weren't actually made out of buffalo. Most of all, she loved how Adora had no issue with telling Catra she loved her completely at random, and voicing all of the little admirations they had for her.

"I love you too," Catra said, quietly, as Adora walked back into the bedroom, warm, damp towel in hand and now dry glasses resting on her nose. Adora pressed the fabric against her slit, and Catra hissed at the over stimulating pressure. Adora choked out a *'I'm sorry!'* that she waved off, reassuring them that they hadn't hurt her. It didn't take long before Adora was done, and the towel was tossed into a nearby hamper.

"So, now what?"

"Last I remember, you've only had a PB-and-J today, and that means you need to eat something." Adora started to say something, but Catra kept talking, "You're not allowed to say no, not unless you want Melog to sleep on your pillow tonight. You're eating something, that's an order."

***

Adora and Catra had ended up in their kitchenette quickly after that; Catra was too hungry for post-sex cuddles, and honestly, Adora felt the same way. They had thrown on some shorts and a loose t-shirt with the Brightmoon logo on it, while Catra had put on a black and red silk

robe. It was tied loose enough that Adora was able to see the curve of one of her breasts, as well where her thighs connected into her ass, as they watched Catra bend over to get a pan from a cupboard.

“I was thinking eggs and rice?” Catra called out to Adora, their focus still exclusively on the pile of cookware in front of them. “And I’m making a stir-fry with some veggies for you since you haven’t eaten today.”

Catra’s words sunk into Adora like pitons, the feeling of guilt starting to fill up her mind again. She really hadn’t eaten today, and they knew how much Catra worried about them taking care of themselves. It was so impossible for Adora to convince herself to eat though. Her thoughts about it were so toxic; she had been told her whole life that she had to earn the right to a full meal, and that had spiraled into them truly believing they didn’t even *deserve* to eat sometimes.

The familiar softness of a hand on her jaw pulled Adora back from the brink, her vision refocusing as she took in Catra’s unpaired eyes waiting for an answer, her ears fallen to the sides with concern. Damnit, she had zoned out again, her cheeks starting to burn red.

“I’m s- sorry, what did you say? I.. I missed it...” Her voice was tiny, barely a squeak. Catra let out a small sigh and her ears fell a little further. Adora always felt so awful when this happened; she knows how much Catra cares about her, but she just doesn’t understand *why* when she’s like this all the time.

“You have *nothing* to feel guilty about. Are you okay baby?” There was a hint of panic in Catra’s voice, and Adora immediately latched onto it.

“Yeah I’m- I’m fine. Just out of it, like I said.”

“I’m sorry if I pressured you into something Adora. I know we have safe words, but that doesn’t mean-” No! No, this isn’t Catra’s fault. She needs to say that out loud and reassure her, but Adora’s words are trapped behind a dry knot in their throat. She needs to let Catra know she didn't do anything wrong! Gods, why is she like this, she just wanted to reassure Catra and she *can't*.

She has to, though.

It hurts like hell, but they force themself to speak.

“No! I mean, Catra-” They stumble over their words, struggling to assemble the right ones in a way that will ease Catra’s fears of hurting her. “You didn’t pressure me. I wanted to do everything we did.”

“You promise?” It’s a knife through Adora’s heart to hear Catra make her promise, but they knew she had every reason to be worried. It was their own fault anyway.

“Yeah, I promise kitten.”

Catra's ears don't change positions, but at least a smile grows. Her eyes seem softer, full of understanding and worry and love as she pulls Adora down and into a small kiss.

Catra goes back to tending to their meal, pulling half a pepper and some carrots from the fridge and placing them on a cutting board. Leaning against the wall, she watches her girlfriend's nimble hands make short work of the vegetables and eggs, adding spices where needed, and constantly adjusting the temperature, as Adora's mind falls back into old habits.

This week has been brutal on her. The anxieties she normally has a handle on, that she's not ever allowed to want things or take a break, have completely escaped her grasp and run wild in her head. She can hear it, the creeping insidious sensation of doubt slowly working to undo all of the healing she's done.

It's been three years since her and Catra got out of the group home, but sometimes when they close their eyes, she can still hear Miss Weaver's lectures. She would go on for hours whenever Adora or Catra made any kind of mistake, talking about how Adora needs to do better and she can't let herself be held back by Catra. Bow told her the term *'Conditional Love'* the first, and only, time she talked about it to him, and the words rang in her mind.

She had been drunk that night, a few months into her first year at college. She had only come out to Bow a few weeks prior, and one night when Catra was away for the weekend on a theatre trip, Adora had shown up outside his dorm. They laughed and played games and talked about their mutual experiences with their bodies, and that had devolved into Adora telling stories from when her and Catra were kids.

"And then, and then," their words slurred together, the alcohol warm in the pit of her stomach. Adora knew she was drunk, and she hadn't planned *on getting drunk, but that was okay! She was with one of her best friends! She loved Bow! And she was telling the best story about Catra, "we both found Octavia and I told her she had a stupid face too!"*

Laughter erupted from the two of them, the mediocre punchline swallowed by the joy in the room. Bow wiped a tear from his eye, still trying to quiet his chuckling so Adora could continue. "She chased after us, but Miss Weaver stopped her. She grounded Catra and gave me a huge lecture about why she weighs me down. Honestly, I was just happy she didn't hurt me, or Catra for that-"

'Wait, what?" The energy in the room changed in an instant. It was no longer warm and inviting, Bow's tone conveying concern and seriousness. Adora's mind raced to understand what had changed; sure, Miss Weaver was always harsh to her and Catra, but it wasn't ever bad*. Not really, not often. "Why would she hit you? You were just being a kid."*

Adora shrugged, struggling to find the words to properly explain what Miss Weaver was trying to get across.

"Normally would just hurt Catra physically, though I would try and get in between them to protect her. I got hurt sometimes too, but i t wasn't a big deal. I was responsible for everybody in the home, especially Catra. As long as I did what she asked and Catra didn't

make any mistakes, she wouldn't actually hurt us. I was more concerned about protecting Catra, honestly. Miss Weaver had it out for her."

"Adora, that's really messed up."

"Is it?" Adora had always known things were harder for her and Catra than the other kids, but she figured most people had it bad. Her high school was specifically for kids with rough upbringings, so she had never really thought about it. Sure, a lot of the people she met at Brightmoon University had nicer parents, but Miss Weaver wasn't horrible.

"Yeah, Adora, it is. You both were given conditional love, which is a terrible thing to do to someone! Imagine not loving a child completely, it's- it's just wrong. I'm sorry you had to go through that, Adora." Bow's hand was on her shoulder now, and for some reason she felt like she needed to cry. It was like she had swallowed a black hole, this impossible weight in her gut that was absorbing everything around it. She did her best to push it down, to stifle the tears before they came, and it mostly worked.

"Yeah, I guess so. Can you- Umm... Can you tell me more about your dads?"

It felt invasive to ask, but the churning guilt in her stomach needed this conversation to move on. The night continued, but no matter how hard Adora tried, she couldn't get her mind off of the idea of 'Conditional Love'.

When she got home that night, she cried until daybreak.

Catra put the salt and pepper grinders back where they belonged, and turned the heat off the stove. It had taken her a bit to learn the timing, but now she was able to make meals that finished cooking in unison.

"Adora, would you mind grabbing us some bowls?" Catra didn't look back as she said it. She was putting the finishing touches on the meals, after all. When she heard sniffling at the same time she smelled the distinct saltiness of tears. Her ears shot up, rotating towards the sound as her fur stood slightly on edge.

"Adora?" She looked over her shoulder as she spoke, already knowing what she would find. Adora's head was in one of her hands, the other supporting the weight by holding her elbow. Hearing her name, Adora looked upwards and saw Catra. They quickly tried to wipe away the tears, before moving towards where the bowls were kept. "Are you okay?"

They stopped mid-movement, the cupboard open and their hand on the bowls. They were frozen like a statue. Catra could smell the panic pouring off of them. She watched as they slowly retrieved two grey plastic bowls, putting them down on the table before pressing her palms into the surface. Adora barely shook her head no, the movement almost imperceptible if not for the momentum her ponytail carried.

Catra walked over, her hand hovering barely an inch above Adora's shoulder.

“Can I touch you?”

A small nod of consent, and Catra was rubbing the tension out of Adora’s shoulder. She felt how deep the knots in their muscles were, and she pressed the pads of her thumbs harder into the flesh, forcing it to yield slightly. Slowly, she spun her around and brought them into a tight hug. With her ear pressed to their sternum, she could hear, hell, she could *feel* Adora’s heart beat like a jackhammer. It’s loud enough that it almost hurt her sensitive hearing, but she pressed harder into Adora’s chest. Wrapping her tail around Adora, a few moments passed before Catra spoke up again.

“Love, can you tell me what’s wrong?”

Adora shakes her head, pain and guilt clearly painted on their face. Catra squeezes their bicep, hoping to anchor them in reality before anything really bad sets in. Her other hand rests on the side of their head, turning it downward so their eyes can meet. Adora’s are squeezed shut, but slowly, they let them fall open, and Catra instantly knows what’s wrong.

Sometimes, when Adora is having a particularly rough moment, she’ll lose her words. Her mind flashes back to Glimmer saying something along the lines of Adora going "non-verbal" the first, and only, time she witnessed it. It’s been happening less and less, thankfully, but it still always worries Catra whenever it happens. They have systems in place to help them communicate, including writing notes on their phone and even tracing short words into Catra’s palms, and it’s a good safety system. It works. But it isn’t enough to keep Catra’s heart from burning with fear and pain for Adora, and white hot rage for their mutual abuser.

“Do you still want to eat?”

Catra’s words are soft, encouraging and guiding Adora to try and think about something static and real. It takes her a few moments before they reach up and gently pull on one of Catra’s hands. Letting her arm go limp, Adora takes control and tenderly flips her palm towards the ceiling, cautiously writing *[YES]* into Catra’s fur. She nods, and plants a small kiss on Adora’s hand as it pulls away.

“Okay. I’ll serve the food and meet you at the table in a sec?” Catra practically shoves the words out, her body demanding for nothing more than to hold her girlfriend and soothe her. She knows how Adora works, though, and food always makes her feel better, especially if she hasn’t eaten all day.

Adora slowly leaves the small kitchenette, shuffling from the room and towards the table, her tablet still open to her history textbook. Catra makes two servings of their meal, she’ll box up the leftovers for breakfast later, and sits down. Reaching out, she wraps her fingers around Adora’s wrist and adds,

“Thank you. I’m proud of you.”

Adora eats her food in silence, sneaking glances at Catra every now and again. Melog has come to join them, jumping up and sitting on the corner of their small table. It’s big enough

for the two of them, just, giving the corner and air of safety. Catra fills most of her vision, anchoring her firmly to reality.

She feels terrible for going silent on Catra, her anxiety beating against her mind like a war drum. Catra has reassured her time and time again that it isn't their fault, and that it's okay, but Adora never fully believes her. Whenever this happened at the group home, she'd get yelled at until she spoke, or until Weaver got bored and hurt her. Sometimes, she'd even hurt Catra to force Adora to speak. It reinforced this idea that by not talking, she had failed someone, anyone, and anything that happened because of it was exclusively their fault. Catra had gone on for ages that none of that was true, but…

It was hard to believe, especially when it had caused Catra so much pain.

By the time she had gotten to the bottom of her bowl, she was already feeling better. She knew cognitively that eating always brightened her mood, but in the moment it was so hard to see that. She felt blinded by fear when it happened, paralyzing her and sending her into a tailspin.

"How are you feeling princess?" Catra looked at them, her smile soft and full of understanding. She looked exhausted, which wasn't a surprise considering it was well past midnight.

Adora readied herself to force words out, but they came easier to her now than they had all day.

"I'm feeling okay? The food- It helped. Thank you."

"Anything for you Adora. You know that, right?" Her question was punctuated by grabbing Adora's hand and clamping down on it. They returned the gesture, holding Catra's hand and giving comforting pressure to their partner, a telltale sign that they were feeling better.

"The same for you Catra."

Catra raised an eyebrow.

"You didn't say 'I know'."

Fuck.

Adora was hoping to avoid Catra calling her out like that. They had so much trouble accepting help that they'd rather fail a class than ask their girlfriend, *who is the best tutor at the school*, for help with an assignment. It drove Catra up the wall and always made Adora feel awful. She didn't want to ever ask for help, not because she didn't need it, but because she knew she didn't *deserve* it. She wasn't worth the time, and the resources were better spent on other students, people who needed more help than her. No matter how many times Catra told her that was a stupid train of thought, Adora struggled to internalize it.

They squeezed their eyes shut, taking a breath deep into their lungs before exhaling and opening her eyes again. She had to believe what Catra was telling her was true.

She had to.

“I know Catra.”

“Good, because I’m going to tattoo it inside your eyelids soon, dummy.” Catra said, with no malice in her words at all, only admiration and pride.

“I’m s-”

“Nope, no apologies.” Catra’s sentence immediately filled the space Adora was planning on using, the conversation now solely Catra’s to speak. “You aren’t allowed to apologize for having a bad day. You’re a person, and you’re allowed to want things and feel things. Most importantly, you’re allowed to ask for help, *especially* from me. I’m not mad at you Adora, but why didn’t you call me?”

She could hear the disappointment in Catra's voice. The worry has clear behind her mismatched, blue-and-yellow eyes. Why didn’t they call Catra? Adora knew this was a bad day, and Catra has given her explicit permission to call her whenever. Adora thought back to when they had butt-dialed her while working out and Catra walked out of a midterm to make sure everything was okay. She even sent Scorpia to go check on Adora since she wasn’t responding to messages, and she wasn’t allowed to physically leave. Not like that would have stopped her if something was really wrong.

To Adora, it was simple, really; she didn’t want to bother Catra. They knew she had better things to do than help her, and she was at work today anyway. With a shrug, Adora managed to respond with *'You were busy?'* It's a blatant lie, but it hurts less to say than the truth.

“Bullshit Adora, that wouldn't be a good excuse even *if* you weren't lying.” And she was right, it wasn’t an excuse. “Before you say ‘I didn’t want to bother you’, you know that’s also not a good reason. I *love* you Adora, and I want to be here for you whenever you need it, since you are for me. You always sacrifice so much for everybody, especially me, and I want to do that for you. I just wish I knew how to help you get that.”

Catra’s ears were pressed outwards now, flat and long, and her tail was swishing slightly. Her fingers were still wrapped around Adora’s, her thumb rubbing the back of their hand. Melog was purring quietly, subtly vibrating the table. Catra looked at them, *really* looked at them and burned holes through Adora’s thick walls and into her heart.

Adora couldn’t match their gaze, not completely, and their eyes fell to their interlocked hands with a small huff. Sleep was pulling at her mind now, blurring her thoughts with it’s begs to be unconscious. She hadn’t been sleeping well, either, with her nightmares resurfacing. Stress did that, and other nasty things, to her, but she was feeling better now. She had eaten, she was clean, she had gotten off, and most of all, Catra was home.

“I know. I know that’s not an excuse. I did want to text you,” which is true, the unfinished text in her drafts was all the proof they needed, “I just… couldn’t. I’m working on it, I promise.”

Catra seemed comforted by the knowledge, especially since it wasn't long ago that Adora wouldn't even have considered the idea.

"I love you, Catra."

Catra rolled her eyes at that, a habit of hers that Adora can't remember her ever not doing. Still, she squeezed Adora's hand tighter. Adora tried to suppress a yawn, but it didn't work. When her sight came back, Catra was looking at her, a wide smile that was all fangs and her eyes full of love.

"Let's go to sleep, okay? I'm exhausted, and to be honest that's mostly your fault from fucking me into the bed so hard. But don't think this conversation is over. I'm making you talk about your feelings tomorrow." Sticking her tongue out, Catra added, "Eugh, gross, I sound like CropTop or Sparkles."

Catra stood from the table, sending Adora away from the kitchen with a small kiss. She joined her a few minutes later in the bathroom, food now safely away in the fridge, and they began their nightly ritual. Being domestic like this with Catra brought color to Adora's mind again, burning away the last of the anxiety. Catra was right, though, they had to finish this conversation tomorrow, even if she *really* didn't want to.

As they climbed into bed and shut the light off, Melog came running in and claimed a spot pressed into Adora's chest. With Catra spooning her and purring, she had two sets of rumbles to help lull her to rest. Before the hopeful bliss of sleep took her, a familiar thought nestled into her heart;

Catra was home.

The person who always made her feel safe, who confided in her and who she confided in, their best friend in all of existence, the very person she would fight the whole universe for, was home.

Sure, she was physically in their shared apartment, arms wrapped tightly around Adora's waist and her body was pressed into her back in a comfortable snuggle, but that's not what they meant.

Catra *was* her home.

Chapter End Notes

For now, considering this a one-off, but there may very well be more added. I have a few ideas for other stories to tell in this AU, but I also wanted to write post-canon fic, or pieces for my military scifi AU, or my D&D fantasy AU. We'll see what happens.

End Notes

I have so many feelings about Adora and Catra and specifically this AU please send help. Also, the Trans Adora tag needs more pieces. It can never have enough.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!